

Deep ties: On India-Maldives ties

India needs to engage its neighbours more closely

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's **visit** to the Maldives last week, after an invitation by Maldives President Mohamed Muizzu to be a special guest for the country's 60th Independence Day, **signalled** the full return of relations to the **closeness** they held during the previous Ibrahim Solih government. **Although** the two leaders had not **gotten off to the best start** in 2023, after Mr. Muizzu's surprise win, **backed** by an "India Out" campaign — this was followed by a "Boycott Maldives" social media campaign in India — they have **been on the mend** for the past year. During Mr. Muizzu's 2024 state visit to India, India had announced measures including **lines of credit** and a **currency swap arrangement** to support the Maldives during its economic troubles. Mr. Muizzu **reflected gratitude** when he described India's role in the Maldives as "**pivotal**" and Mr. Modi **reciprocated** the **warmth**. India announced a line of credit worth \$565 million (₹4,850 crore) and reduced the annual **debt** burden for Maldives on previous Indian lines of credit by 40%. There was also the launch of India-Maldives Free Trade Agreement **negotiations**, which will be a significant **driver** of future **engagement**. There was the signing too of **MoUs** for cooperation in fisheries, **meteorological** sciences, digital solutions and pharma, as well as a digital and rupee-rufiyaa national currency payments agreement. Over the past six **decades**, India has **cultivated** a strong security partnership with the Maldives, including **trilateral** national security consultations with Sri Lanka, and it is significant that after Mr. Modi's visit, Mr. Muizzu welcomed Sri Lankan President Anura Kumara Dissanayake for a state visit.

The Maldives visit was also a **reaffirmation** of the importance of India's "Neighbourhood First" policy, at a time when Indian foreign policy is facing **headwinds** linked to the U.S.'s trade tariffs and the conflicts in Ukraine and Gaza. The **conflict** with Pakistan after the Pahalgam attacks, and **tensions** with Bangladesh **have** engaged the government's attention. New Delhi has also been **preoccupied** with **reaching out** to different countries, **following** Operation Sindoor, but did not send **delegations** to neighbouring countries. It is **heartening** that New Delhi is preparing to welcome Nepal Prime Minister K.P. Sharma Oli, who has not been invited to India since he took office a year ago. A **commemorative stamp** by the Maldives for its national day celebrations **showed** traditional Indian and Maldives boats, which Mr. Modi described as a **reflection** of India and the Maldives being not just neighbours "but also **fellow voyagers** on a shared journey". In a time of global economic **turmoil**, a closer **engagement** with the neighbours — one that **shores up** their economic needs and supports their plans for development where possible — **is essential**.

[Practice Exercise]

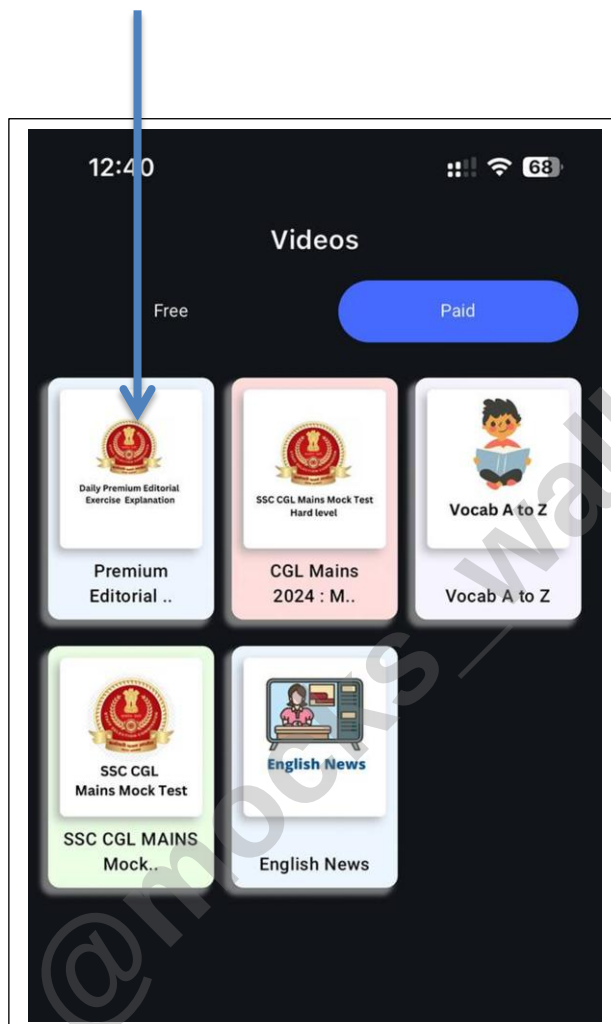
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- **a currency swap arrangement** (noun) – an agreement in which two parties exchange the principal amount of a loan and the interest in one currency for the principal and interest in another currency.

Vocabulary

1. **Deep** (adjective) – intense, profound, strong, heartfelt, serious गहरा
2. **Ties** (noun) – connections, bonds, links, relationships, affiliations संबंध
3. **Signal** (verb) – indicate, show, mark, suggest, announce संकेत देना
4. **Closeness** (noun) – intimacy, nearness, proximity, togetherness, familiarity निकटता
5. **Although** (conjunction) – though, even though, while, albeit, whereas हालाँकि
6. **Get off to a good start** (phrase) – begin well, start positively, launch successfully, initiate favourably, commence smoothly शुभारंभ होना
7. **Back** (verb) – support, endorse, advocate, promote, uphold समर्थन करना
8. **Be on the mend** (phrase) – recovering, improving, healing, getting better, stabilizing सुधार की ओर होना
9. **Line of credit** (noun) – a type of loan that lets you borrow money up to a pre-set limit ऋण सुविधा
10. **Reflect** (verb) – show, express, indicate, demonstrate, reveal प्रतिबिंबित करना
11. **Gratitude** (noun) – thankfulness, appreciation, recognition, indebtedness, gratefulness कृतज्ञता
12. **Pivotal** (adjective) – crucial, key, central, essential, vital महत्वपूर्ण
13. **Reciprocate** (verb) – return, respond, repay, acknowledge, reflect back परस्पर लेन-देन करना
14. **Warmth** (noun) – affection, kindness, friendliness, cordiality, sincerity सौहार्द
15. **Debt** (noun) – liability, loan, obligation, dues, arrears कर्ज
16. **Negotiation** (noun) – discussion, talks, deliberation, dialogue, bargaining बातचीत
17. **Driver** (noun) – force, catalyst, influence, trigger, factor कारक
18. **Engagement** (noun) – involvement, participation, interaction, association, commitment संपर्क / भागीदारी
19. **MoUs** (noun) – A Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) is a non-binding agreement between two or more parties that outlines the terms of a potential agreement or collaboration. समझौता ज्ञापन
20. **Meteorological** (adjective) – climatic, weather-related, atmospheric, environmental, forecasting मौसम संबंधी

21. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years, दशक
22. **Cultivate** (verb) – develop, build, foster, nurture, maintain विकसित करना / बढ़ावा देना
23. **Trilateral** (adjective) – three-party, tripartite, three-sided, triangular, threefold त्रिपक्षीय
24. **Reaffirmation** (noun) – confirmation, restatement, endorsement, assertion, renewal पुनः पुष्टि
25. **Headwind** (noun) – obstacle, resistance, hindrance, difficulty, adversity विरोधी स्थिति
26. **Preoccupied** (with) (adjective) – absorbed, concerned, engaged, distracted, busy व्यस्त / चिंतित
27. **Reach out** (phrasal verb) – contact, approach, connect, communicate, engage संपर्क करना
28. **Following** (preposition) – after, subsequent to, ensuing, as a result of, in the wake of के पश्चात्
29. **Delegation** (noun) – representatives, envoy, team, mission, deputation प्रतिनिधिमंडल
30. **Heartening** (adjective) – encouraging, uplifting, reassuring, comforting, pleasing उत्साहजनक
31. **Commemorative** (adjective) – memorial, celebratory, honouring, dedicatory, respectful स्मृति चिन्ह संबंधी
32. **Reflection** (noun) – image, expression, indication, mirror, portrayal झलक
33. **Fellow** (adjective) – companion, co-, mutual, peer, associate साथी
34. **Voyager** (noun) – traveller, explorer, adventurer, navigator, wanderer यात्री
35. **Turmoil** (noun) – unrest, chaos, disorder, upheaval, confusion अशांति / उथल-पुथल
36. **Shore up** (phrasal verb) – support, strengthen, reinforce, back up, bolster सुदृढ़ करना / समर्थन देना
37. **Essential** (adjective) – necessary, crucial, vital, indispensable, fundamental अत्यावश्यक

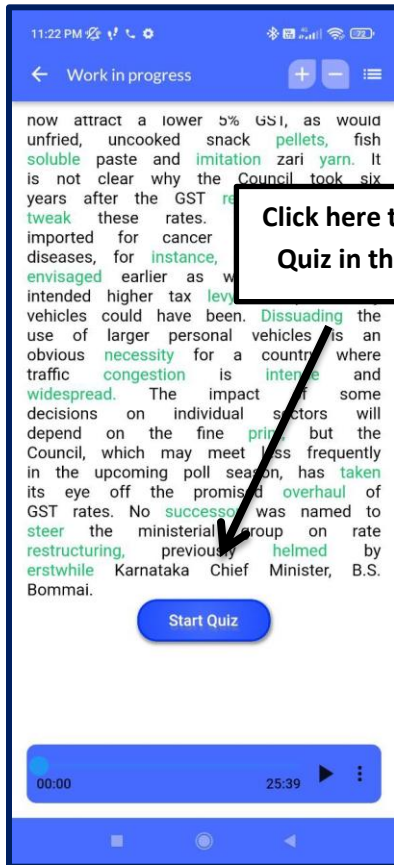
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



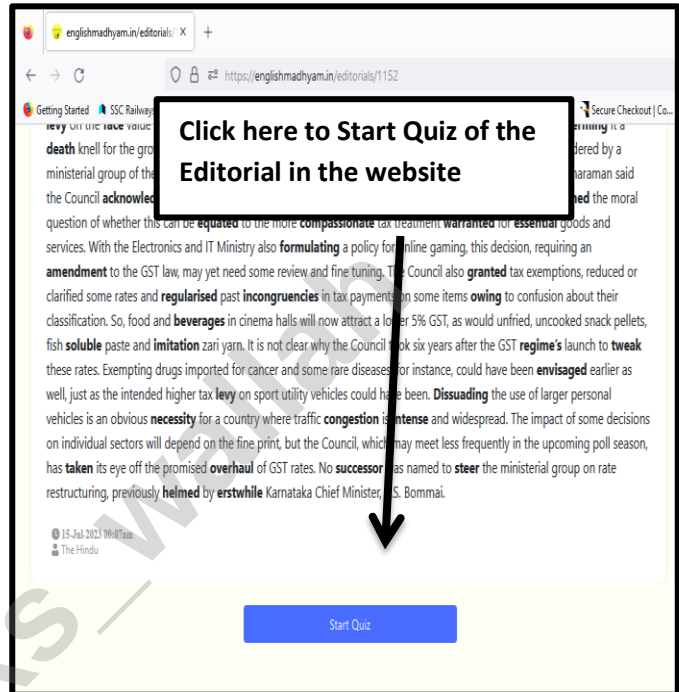
Summary of the Editorial

1. **PM Narendra Modi visited the Maldives** as the special guest for its 60th Independence Day celebrations, invited by President Mohamed Muizzu.
2. This visit **marked a revival of close India-Maldives ties**, resembling the warmth seen during former President Ibrahim Solih's tenure.
3. Relations had **soured in 2023**, after Muizzu's win was supported by the anti-India "India Out" campaign, followed by India's "Boycott Maldives" backlash.
4. **Efforts to mend ties** began with Muizzu's 2024 state visit to India, where India announced key economic support.
5. India extended a **\$565 million line of credit** and **reduced Maldives' annual debt burden** on earlier Indian credit lines by 40%.
6. Muizzu acknowledged India's **"pivotal" role**, while Modi reciprocated the positive sentiment.
7. Both nations **initiated Free Trade Agreement (FTA) talks**, which are expected to boost long-term engagement.
8. Several **MoUs were signed** on cooperation in fisheries, digital solutions, meteorological sciences, pharmaceuticals, and digital payments.
9. A **rupee-rufiyaa national payments system** was also agreed upon to facilitate smoother bilateral trade.
10. India and Maldives have enjoyed **decades-long security ties**, including trilateral cooperation with Sri Lanka.
11. Following Modi's visit, **Maldives welcomed Sri Lankan President Anura Kumara Dissanayake**, reinforcing regional cooperation.
12. The visit reaffirmed **India's "Neighbourhood First" policy**, especially during challenging global and regional developments.
13. India's foreign policy currently faces **external challenges**, such as U.S. trade tariffs and conflicts in Ukraine and Gaza.
14. Regional concerns — like **tensions with Pakistan (post-Pahalgam attacks)** and Bangladesh — have required New Delhi's diplomatic focus.
15. The editorial concludes by urging **closer economic and developmental engagement** with neighbours during global uncertainty, emphasizing shared regional progress.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



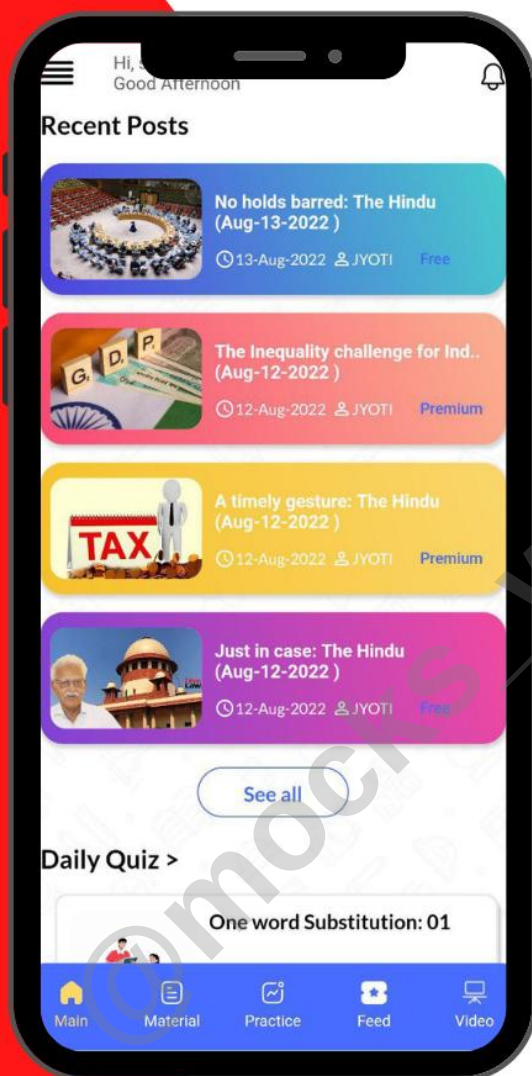
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